Seated Flow #1

This seated flow explores the six movements of the spine, helping to release tension and cultivate a more optimal internal environment for seated meditation.

As you guide this sequence, continue to reinforce slow, deep and full breath. This will help your students cultivate both concentration and relaxation. Encourage them repeatedly not to push beyond 75 percent of their capacity.

Preparation for Sitting
Centering Breath
Sun Breath and Moving Meditation
Side Stretch
Twist Stretch
Chest-Opening Stretch
Forward Bend
Alignment and Preparation for Meditation

INTRODUCTION

For the next few minutes I will be guiding a a sequence of sitting postures. There are a few things to keep in mind:

1. Remember to breathe with slow, full deep breaths. You'll find that as you keep the breath at the center of your experience, it will help ensure you stay present to all that is happening inside. You'll naturally forget your breathing, of course—but when you do, return your attention to this breathing technique.
2. These movements are designed to be both gentle and powerful. Please do not extend beyond 75 percent of your capacity in any stretch.
3. Finally, if there is anything I lead that doesn't feel right for you and your body, please do what feels right for you.

PREPARATION FOR SITTING

For the sequence, sense if you can sit without any back support.

If you need some back support, I would encourage you to use a cushion and place it down to your lower back in such a way that you are slightly tilting your spine forward.

Take this time to close your eyes.

Place your feet flat on the floor, hands resting gently in your lap or on the tops of your thighs.

Press your buttocks and especially the sitting bones down into the chair. Gently draw your navel and toward your spine.

Relax the back of the neck and along the base of the skull, and imagine here a gentle lengthening of the entire neck.

CENTERING BREATH

Notice whether your breath is effortless or labored. Notice where you feel your breath the most predominant inside and let your attention go there. Sense if you can release any tension that may be inhibiting the easy flow of breath.

As you're ready, began to lengthen the breath. You might inhale slowly to the count of five and exhale slowly to the count of five. As you find your way, let the length of the inhalation match the length of the exhalation.

As you move through these postures, let your breath be in the foreground of your awareness.

SUN BREATH AND MOVING MEDITATION

With your eyes closed with a soft gaze, gently turn your palms so they're facing out to either side of you.

Slowly inhale as you draw the arms out to the sides, reaching up overhead.

If you can, bring the fingertips and the palms together in prayer position and, as you slowly exhale, draw the hands down through the midline of your body.

Again, inhale as you draw the arms out to the side, reaching the arms overhead. Fingertips and palms together in prayer position, and exhale the hands down through the midline of the body.

Continue on your own, letting the breath be full and deep.

Continue three to five times.

Notice how as you draw the arms overhead you might be able to draw the breath up under the collarbones, filling the lungs.

You might lift the chin slightly as you inhale, as if you're looking up into the light.

Gently, in your own time, let the arms come down and rest by your sides.

Release all control of the breath. If you like, close your eyes.

Relax and feel. Sense this quality of open, relaxed awareness.

SITTING SIDE STRETCH, RIGHT SIDE

Bring your right hand down to clasp the side of your chair.

Begin to deepen your breath. Inhale slowly to the count of five and exhale slowly to the count of five. As you find the length of breath that works for you, try to match the length of the in-breath with the length of the out-breath.

Press down into the chair through the buttocks and especially the sitting bones at the base of your pelvis.

Extend the left palm out to the side. Length through the left arm and as you breathe, slowly draw that arm up overhead.

Gently lengthen the spine and invite the torso to gently stretch over toward your right side.

Ensure you are not extending beyond 75 percent of your capacity.

Gently engage all the muscles on the left side of the body, allowing them to simultaneously lengthen and relax.

What could lengthen a little bit more on the inhalation?

What do you feel on the exhalation?

What happens if you draw your left shoulder blade back slightly?

Slowly release the arm down to your side.

Close your eyes and take one full, deep breath.

What do you feel, what do you notice?

SITTING SIDE STRETCH, LEFT SIDE

Bring your left hand down to clasp the side of your chair.

Begin to deepen your breath, long, smooth and full. Inhale slowly to the count of five and exhale slowly to the count of five. As you find the length of breath that works for you, try to match the length of the in-breath with the length of the out-breath.

Press down into the chair through the buttocks and especially the sitting bones at the base of your pelvis.

Extend the right palm out to the side. Length through the right arm and as you breathe, slowly draw that arm up overhead.

Gently lengthened to the spine and invite the torso to gently stretch over toward your left side.

Ensure you are not extending beyond 75 percent of your capacity.

Gently engage all the muscles on the right side of the body, allowing them to simultaneously lengthen and relax.

What could lengthen a little bit more on the inhalation?

What do you feel on the exhalation?

What happens if you draw your right shoulder blade back slightly?

Slowly release the arm down to your side.

Close your eyes and take one full, deep breath.

What do you feel, what do you notice?

SITTING TWIST, RIGHT SIDE

As you prepare for the sitting twist to the right side, begin to deepen and establish your breath, full and slow and deep.

Extend your left hand out in front of you and bring that hand to the outside of your right knee.

Bring your right hand to your right hip or, if it's comfortable for you, you can hook your right arm on the back of the chair behind you.

Facing forward, establish the breath: full and deep and slow.

Press down through the floor of the pelvis.

Gently draw the navel in, elongating the spine up and out of the waist.

Tuck the chin slightly and lengthen through the back of the neck.

Very gently, track the horizon with your eyes as you draw your chin toward your right shoulder.

As you inhale, sense what could lengthen on the inside.

As you exhale, notice all the details on the inside.

As you continue to breathe and explore, can you find that place where you are engaged without strain?

Where is the breath right now?

Gently release and return to center.

Close your eyes and feel inside.

SITTING TWIST, LEFT SIDE

As you prepare for the sitting twist to the left side, begin to deepen and establish your breath, full and slow and deep.

Extend your right hand out in front of you and bring that hand to the outside of your left knee.

Bring your left hand to your left hip or, if it's comfortable for you, you can hook your left arm on the back of the chair behind you.

Facing forward, establish the breath: full and deep and slow.

Press down through the floor of the pelvis.

Gently draw the navel in, elongating the spine up and out of the waist.

Tuck the chin slightly and lengthen through the back of the neck.

Very gently, track the horizon with your eyes as you draw your chin toward your left shoulder.

As you inhale, sense what could lengthen on the inside.

As you exhale, notice all the details on the inside.

As you continue to breathe and explore, can you find that place where you are engaged without strain?

Where is the breath right now?

Gently release and return to center.

Close your eyes and feel inside.

CHEST-OPENING STRETCH

Deepen your breath, slow and full.

Press down through the floor of your pelvis.

Relax and lengthen through the back of your neck.

Sit comfortably with your spine lengthened.

Open your arms out to either side as you turn your palms forward and extend through your fingers.

Alternatively, you can place your hands on your hips.

Squeeze the shoulder blades together.

Pull the shoulder blades down a little bit.

As you breathe, imagine you are opening your chest and breathing your heart forward.

If it's comfortable for you, lift the chin just slightly.

If it is possible, breathe a little bit fuller, a little bit deeper.

What could lengthen on the in-breath? What do you feel on the out-breath?

Again, bring your attention back to the breath, noticing everything you feel on the inside.

In these final moments, notice everywhere you feel holding and contraction.

Slowly, now release any sense of holding. Relax all control of the breath.

Relax and feel.

Sense a quality of allowing. A sense of relaxed, open awareness.

FORWARD BEND STRETCH

Deepen your breath, slow and full.

Place your palms on the tops of your thighs.

Slowly hinge forward from the hips and gently bring your torso down on the tops of your thighs.

Let your attention flow with the breath.

Notice everything you feel on the inside.

Relax your neck. Relax the muscles of your face.

Before you begin your return, imagine you could stack the spine, placing one vertebra on top of another.

When you're ready, slowly draw yourself up to a sitting position.

ALIGNMENT AND PREPARATION FOR MEDITATION

As you come into a seated position for meditation, gently scan through your body.

Feet flat on the floor.

Back unsupported or with a cushion or blanket at your lower back, with the pelvis slightly tilted forward.

Soften your belly.

Relax through the back of your neck and the base of the skull.

Relax and soften your hands.

Let your breath be effortless. Notice where you feel the breath the most predominant on the inside.